strategy in 1940 decimated Allied forces in six weeks. The key elements of German strategy were the concentration of highly mobile forces led by tanks, the use of surprise, and the massive use of dive-bombers in support of ground forces that broke through French and British lines and raced towards Paris causing a collapse of Allied defences. Crucially, the Germans delivered supplies efficiently in the field to sustain their advances. In sum, strategy and logistics proved decisive against superior numbers.

For a variety of reasons, war between India and China will be quite different. Terrain will not permit a blitzkrieg: the Himalaya are not the plains of France. Yet the broad principles of modern warfare cannot be ignored: the ability to concentrate forces, to support ground forces with devastating air attacks, to achieve surprise, to advance rapidly towards command-and-control centres, to interrupt communications and disrupt decision-making, and to supply fast-moving forces. Despite a balance of military power, the right offensive strategy can bring victory. Equally, defending forces must pay attention to the ability to locate and move quickly to counter the opponent's massing forces, to prevent the attacker's air force achieving superiority in the skies, to launch unexpected counteroffensives, to maintain communication and orderly retreats and regrouping, and to supply even embattled and surrounded units. An offence can be blunted by a nimble defence.

Assuming that China is not interested in a war of outright conquest in Ladakh or even in Arunachal Pradesh (despite its claims to the entire state), its options along the border come down to three possibilities. The first is an attack along a broad front as in 1962. The second is to attack in key sectors where its forces can concentrate and achieve local superiority. The third is to go behind India's lines using infiltrating or air-dropped special forces, even as a frontal attack serves to distract and to pin down Indian border units. An attack across a broad front would be a punitive war or bargaining war. It is hard to imagine any goals other than to get India to accept certain kinds of economic or political conditions, to diminish its status internationally, or to occupy territory as a bargaining chip towards a final settlement of the border on China's terms. An attack in key sectors would